

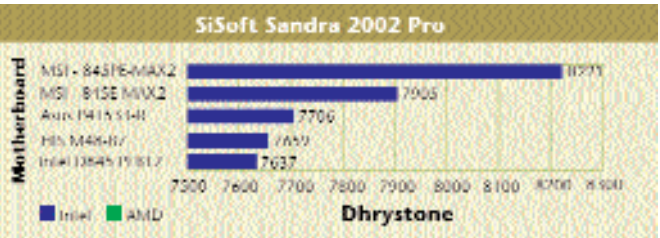
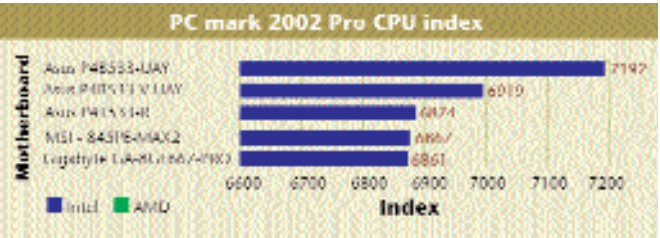
The best motherboards for office and Internet

What kind of a motherboard does one require if one uses office applications along with occasional Internet surfing? A solution that has decent features and brings along good performance. Here a high-end motherboard would not be of much use as it would prove to be overkill. Users in this area also look for value options. Feature laden boards such as the MSI 845PE-Max 2 don't make sense due primarily to their price tag and additionally to the fact that they carry more features than are really needed for this area of application.

In this application area too, motherboards meant for the Intel processors continued to dominate. The Mercury KOB650GL took the first spot with a score of 91.30 STTI. Indeed, the excellent SiS 650 GL chipset gave the board onboard video, onboard sound, USB 2.0 and Ethernet—all the right stuff priced at Rs 3,600. The Intel 845G chipset-based Mercury KOB845G also appeared in the list with a score of 78.16 STTI—this one, however, does not have Ethernet on board.

Two solutions from Krypton managed to grab second and third positions—the Krypton U8668 Z8 and the P4TDQ scored 84.45 and 82.34, respectively. Both had integrated sound and USB 2.0. What separated the U8668 Z8 from the P4TDQ was that the former had Ethernet onboard, which the latter lacked. Bringing up the rear of the Intel pack was the Jetway P4MFM and the HIS M48-DA with scores of 73.64 and 70.47, respectively.

Over to the AMD front. The ASUS A7S266 came out tops. With a price of Rs 5,000 and a score of 81.57 STTI, this board is just the right mix of price, features and performance for an AMD processor. Two Mercurys, the KT266A and the KM266, also did well with 77.48 and 75.19 STTI, respectively. If price is factored in, then the Mercury boards shine even brighter—they are about Rs 1,500 cheaper than the ASUS board. Finally, with a price of Rs 3,650 and a score of 72.18 STTI is the VIA KT333-



Cheap VIA Integration

As of today, the consumer processor and chipset market is split unevenly between arch-rivals Intel and AMD. These companies provide high-end products at exorbitant prices. This keeps a PC out of the reach of one who wishes to use one for rudimentary tasks such as typing a document, surfing the Internet, playing music and exchanging e-mail. For such users, opting for a high-end machine is a serious waste of resource and money.

VIA has been manufacturing the CYRIX brand of processors which were on the lower end as far as price was concerned and they were compatible with any Socket 370 based motherboards, thus providing the ultimate value for money. But these processors never charmed the users. Recently, VIA launched the Eden platform which promises to deliver us into an era of cheap, integrated PCs. Using 0.13 and 0.15 micron technology, form factors are reduced along with power requirement and heat emissions—the solutions operate without cooling fans. Furthermore, the CPU, the Northbridge and the Southbridge are integrated into a single chip. The platform seems attractive since the sound, video and communication ports are embedded on the motherboard itself. The user has a choice of either an Eden ESP processor or a C3 processor. Above all, the entire solution costs half the price of an Intel P4 2.0 GHz processor.

based EPOX EP-8K3A+, an onboard RAID controller being the feature that makes it stand out from the crowd of office and Internet application worthies.

The best processors for office and Internet

The best processors suited for this area are the different variants of the AMD processors, due to their competitive pricing. Indeed, only three processors scored more than 70 STTI in this category, all three AMD. The Athlon XP 1700+ takes the crown here with its impressive performance (83.34 STTI) at an unbeatable price of Rs 3,240. Those looking for the best value option need go no further. The 1800+ and the 2000+ also feature in the short list of three.

For those in the Intel camp, the Celeron 1.7 GHz comes across as the best you can get—priced at Rs 3,550, it is a decent scorer of 68.44 STTI. Everything else is either too costly for this category (such as the P4 3.06 GHz and the AMD XP 2800+) or does not perform to the mark. For instance, take the Intel P4 1.7 GHz—at Rs 7,350 and the lowest score of 49.47 STTI, it could not be more wrong for the application area of office and Internet work.

Our recommended solution

The best office and Internet solution should be competitively priced and should offer good performance and features for everyday usage. This brings us to the ASUS A7S266 board that does

